

Semantic search

You can be certain that some kind of human editorialisation – judgement – will be involved in most new approaches to search. The problem lies of course, in the fact that in some areas, one man's fact is another's heresy. I first became properly aware of this in our industry when reporting on the strange case a few years ago of Microsoft's encyclopedia, Encarta. It turned out that many entries in Encarta would vary depending on the country in which it was to be published. I even found a Microsoft spokesperson on record as stating "Basically, we rewrite the facts for each edition." So, the facts, according to Microsoft, depended upon what country you happened to be in.

One good example was the invention of the telephone. Many potential inventors worked along similar lines, but in the Italian version of Encarta it stated that "the first rudimentary telephone apparatus was invented in 1854 by Italian inventor Antonio Meucci". This chap Meucci received no mention in the UK edition of Encarta. There, of course, the accolade went to Alexander Graham Bell.

I do not know if Microsoft still does this kind of thing, but it is so obviously the wrong way to go. For a start, if there is a dispute over who invented some widget, surely that fact should be mentioned in all references. The British edition of Encarta should have mentioned the Italian as at least having an input into the invention – his work was 22 years before Bell secured his patent. Ideally, the British and Italian versions should have the same information, balanced as objectively and accurately as possible.

Now, apply this to semantic search. I would hope that we would have that kind of balance. However, one simple test: the answer that WolframAlpha gives to the question "Who invented the telephone?" is only Bell. Meucci does not even get a mention – Bell is presented as an objective fact, and this is simply wrong. Even Wikipedia does much better than that, much to my surprise. Read what it says – it makes it quite clear that Meucci had a very good claim, but it was Bell who successfully filed the patent.

Similarly to the example of telephone invention there are many other facts and opinions that are in dispute across cultural or national divides. Surely, one of the great benefits of the internet is that we should be able to have access to both sides of any story, and make up our own minds which we find the most compelling. The internet

helps break down international barriers to information. It does not automatically remove all bias and prejudice, but it certainly helps you find a more objective picture. The last thing we need is some "authority" imposing its world view.

One of the reasons that I like the approach taken by Facility is that it does not restrict itself either to blind searching in the manner of Google or to editorialised computation like WolframAlpha. This means that even if some unwitting bias enters into the editorialised part of the search, there will be plenty of other sources delivered to you which should be free from such bias. It will be interesting later to ask this search engine from Italy just who invented the telephone! Will Bell get a mention? Even if he does not in the main editorialised section of the results - although I doubt that will be the case – he should show up in the section from encyclopedias.

Clearly, users of these new systems will need to use as much care and judgement as they do now when using search engines. Many years ago, when search engines such as AltaVista started to become available, many people were surprised to find that they had to develop a skill in using the search engine, and had to be thoughtful when composing a particular search request. I remember some colleagues being quite proud when they had managed to compose a search request that brought out exactly what was needed, and without it being buried among 50,000 other results.

Just because we are entering the world of semantic search does not mean that such care and attention can be dropped – my simple example with WolframAlpha demonstrates that. We will all need to remember that we will have to work hard and thoughtfully with these new systems. We will be on a learning curve if we are to get the best from these new search engines and benefit from the objectivity that should be a primary feature of using the internet as an information resource.



Edward Henning, Editor-in-Chief

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A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "E. Henning".

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